

Chapter

The Pativrata — Not Suppressed, but Radiant



Introduction: A Question Many Women Ask

If a marriage becomes difficult, if the husband is on the wrong path, if a woman has to suppress her wishes in her in-laws' home — what should she do? Keep enduring, or leave? Acharya Upendra Ji says this question comes to him again and again — in private chat, during sadhana. In this excerpt from a discourse, he answers it from the standpoint of **karma yoga** and on the basis of the scriptures.

His answer begins with a point that overturns the common notion: a **pativrata** is not one who silently keeps being

suppressed; a pativrata is one who has tej — inner radiance — within her.

Pativrata — a woman who upholds the dharma of devotion to her husband. **Karma yoga** — performing one's duties in such a way that they do not become bondage but lead towards liberation.

The True Meaning of Pativrata: Tej

In his very first sentence, Acharya Ji changes the definition of a pativrata:

"Who is called a pativrata woman? She has tej within her; she is said to be a form of the Devi. It is said that in her company **even a rakshasa will become Govind.**"

"Meaning, she definitely **has the power to convert someone into something like the Divine.** And she herself is being suppressed? She has the power of the Devi within her!"

For this strength, he recalls Swami Vivekananda's maxim:

"Swami Vivekananda said, **strength is life, weakness means death.** So she must also know how to speak up with her words."

He gives an example from the life of Sant Eknath Maharaj:

"Eknath Maharaj had a daughter, and she too was married to a somewhat wrong man. So Eknath told her to teach him one verse of the Gita every day. Doing this, **he had improved.**"

Transformation is possible — but for that a woman must recognise her own power:

"When, wherever she has to become divine, then she will have to be **Mahishasura-mardini.** You should have the capacity to bring down his ego."

Mahishasura-mardini — the form of Goddess Durga who slew the arrogant demon Mahishasura.

"What Will People Say" — Whose Fault Is It?

And if a woman does not have this courage? Acharya Ji says plainly that then the problem no longer lies only with the husband:

"Actually, the thought will be in your own mind that 'I should leave him' — 'I can't leave, what will people say.'
So you are at fault, not he."

"So there is not even the courage to leave — 'What will society say, I am staying only for Chunnu and Munnu, otherwise I would have left long ago.' In this there is no happiness. **This is not the life of a pativrata.** There is no energy at all."

Then he asks the women directly whether their inner self accepts this answer as right — and recognises the hesitation born of a thousand years of subjugation:

"The Indian woman today, very much — because of living in subjugation for a thousand years — she might feel, 'Should I say yes or should I not?'... **And she has that power, she can speak.**"

"If she does not do it, then what Vivekananda says — then you are not what you are talking about; then you are not that; **then she is not called a pativrata.**"

The First Two Years: Keep Your True Image

When is this courage to be shown? Acharya Ji gives practical advice — in the early years of marriage:

"You too must, at least once, **learn to say no with confidence.** In the first two years you have to create an image. Then we show a false image, that we do this much, that much; **then that image carries for the rest of the life.**"

"Then they say, 'Now what problem has she got?' — in the third year, for not coming, for not doing. So say it in the first two years itself. **Keep your real image in front:** 'I don't like this, I like this.'"

But saying "no" does not mean harshness:

"Don't speak in a bad tone; **speech is important.** Then after that, **a woman never has to live by killing her own wishes, in the marriage also.**"

Duty and Passion — Both Together

Referring to the householder's dharma in the Vishnu Purana, Acharya Ji says that a woman should express her wishes:

"They say that **she has to express herself.** If she wants to do an MBA course, a part-time course, or something else, if she wants to go to a hobby class, and the mother-in-law says, 'There is work, studies — don't you understand this much?' — **she has to tell in good voice.**"

He explains the reason through the principle of rebirth — an unfinished duty is bondage, and so is a suppressed passion:

"Because that too is duty, and one's hobby, one's passion too. **If that is not fulfilled, there is rebirth; and if this duty is not done, there is rebirth too.**"

So the solution lies in fulfilling both together:

"She should tell: 'Mother-in-law, I will do all this. I will certainly do it after coming back from this class.' So the promise of 'I will do it' is in it, that got done, and she pursued her hobby too. Or the reverse: 'After finishing this, I am going to go here for an hour or two.' **And that much courage she should have.**"

When That Doesn't Work: A Little Distance, With the Husband

If even this does not work, Acharya Ji describes the next step — speaking to the husband, and if needed, raising the idea of living apart for some time:

"If not, then **she should know how to speak to her husband**. The scriptures have said — nuclear family, meaning away for a little time; **not by breaking the relationship**, she should also know how to give the warning of going away for that much time."

"Not the 'I will go to my mother's house' kind — I will **take my husband along with me**."

He explains the psychology of this in a light-hearted way:

"Because her heart will be stuck in both: she wants to shout at the daughter-in-law, that is also her hobby; and she wants to keep her son in her control, that too."

And he reminds us that all this requires inner strength:

"So from the angle of karma yoga, this much is the answer given to it. **But for that she must have tej, she must have her sadhana**."

The Last Option: Liberation Above All

Then Acharya Ji says something that connects the whole question to the ultimate goal of life — giving the example of Meerabai:

"They have spoken of a last option — as Meerabai was told by her guru, that **the path of liberation is the final aim; husband is not the final aim.** The dharma of a pativrata is one part of her life."

"She has done a lot of good, one part is done, but it is not in liberation. **All karma should lead you to mukti.** Only if you want that can you be a karma yogi."

"Whether it is your relatives or anyone at all, **whoever comes as an obstacle on your path of liberation, regard him as equal to a crore of enemies** — crores of enemies. Whoever comes in the way of liberation — even if she has got a husband who says only this much, 'you are not going to satsang tomorrow' — equal to a crore of enemies."

This idea of "equal to a crore of enemies" is found in the famous verse of Goswami Tulsidas which, according to tradition, was written in reply to Meerabai's question:

jāke priya na rāma-baidehī |
tājie tāhi koṭi bairī sama, jadyapi parama
sanehī | |

"One to whom Ram and Vaidehi (Sita) are not dear
— abandon him as you would ten million enemies,
even if he is most dear to you."
— Goswami Tulsidas, Vinay Patrika

But Acharya Ji stresses that this is the last option, not the first:

"So the last step, the last option has been told: **your liberation is first priority**; then you need to be prepared to leave this. That has been told as a last option; it cannot be the first option."

Atrocities: Not to Be Tolerated

On the path in between, there is no compromise on one thing — physical atrocity:

"If those atrocities happen — it still goes on in villages, perhaps sometimes in cities too — 'brand her, put this on her, give the daughter-in-law trouble, torture her' — then it has been said that **injustice is not to be tolerated.**"

"There she has to immediately answer herself, if it is within limits. If not, then **she has to call her parents**, it has been said — and some action has to be taken, **strict action.**"

The Mother's Role: An Invisible Cord

Now Acharya Ji says something many will find unexpected:

"I always say that **most of the time, the one responsible for creating trouble in that woman's home is her own mother.**"

He explains the reason in the subtle bond between mother and child:

"The connection between mother and daughter is strong — with the son too it is very strong. **Whatever thought comes into her mind, it automatically and immediately affects the girl, the boy.** And the more you do it in worry, in tension, the faster it will be."

"That invisible bond of the mother, it is called the **silver cord connection** — even if the umbilical cord is physically cut, this remains continuous. That is why, if she prays even a little, **it works faster for her own child.**"

Half the Story, Whole the Harm

So daughters too have a responsibility:

"So **ladies also should be responsible** — that one does not complain about everything to the mother. How was it earlier? A letter would go. Now, minute by minute, there will be SMS, WhatsApp."

The problem is that the whole story never reaches the mother:

"She will report today's event, but **what happened in the fifteen days before today's event, that history the girl will never tell.** 'I wanted to bring a red curtain, he didn't let me bring it, he told me to bring a black one — they seem like tamasic people, I am rajasic.'"

"But **the mother can create an image: 'Things are going very badly for her.'** And then she gives her suggestions, 'You also say this, you also do that'... **She can damage the entire relationship.**"

"Now This Is My Home"

Acharya Ji connects this mark of a pativrata to the tradition of kanyadaan:

"A real pativrata says, **'This is my home now; from there I have been given away, the kanyadaan has been done.** I don't need to go there again and again.'"

"Her surname and middle name have also changed; **now this is said to be her real home.** So there she need not keep saying, 'What is wrong here, what is wrong.'"

Today's technology has upset this balance:

"Nowadays phones have started, messages have started, with photos, with videos, video calling — now there will be problems. **This is again not a good sign of a pativrata, according to the scriptures.**"

"If your phone goes to your parents' home too much, there will be problems in your married life; this is guaranteed. And the one responsible for it will be your mother, because it is her good heart — this problem will come from too much goodness. She will not be able to take the fair side. And... because of moha, wrong guidance will go."

The Right Limit of Contact

So should one not keep in touch with the mother at all? Not so. Acharya Ji makes the limit clear:

"When there is a real problem, then you must certainly contact her. If it goes beyond your control, then you have to do it. The rest of the time it is fine — there is a family function, 'come over'... or there is some good news to share, share that. Ideally there should be only that much contact."

"It is not every day, phoning three times a day; this has not been called the mark of a pativrata."

He knows that not everyone will like this:

"So I am telling you the truth — ladies will not find it fitting, **but telling the scriptures is my job. Too much contact leads to problem in your married life.**"

The same applies to daughters settled abroad:

"Four times a day on the phone! You went to America — who sent you? ... You went yourself, didn't you, the marriage was there. **Now that you are alone, make friends with the American people there. ... Also because she went to America, let her live her own life.**"

The Same Applies to the Mothers of Sons

Finally, Acharya Ji makes clear that this is not only about daughters:

"The boy went to America, and his mother keeps phoning him: 'Did you eat? What is this food?' Now, **am I talking about the girl, or about the boy too. Fed up, he will say once, 'No, I will look after myself.'**"

"You sent him there, didn't you, so **let him live independently** for a little time. Otherwise you should have kept him here at home, next to you. So **mothers also have to take care; we have to be very careful.**"

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Being a pativrata means tej, not being suppressed.** A pativrata woman has the power of the Devi — "even a rakshasa will become Govind." Strength is life, weakness is death.
- 2 Enduring misery out of fear of "what will people say" is not the dharma of a pativrata.** "You are at fault, not he" — such a life has neither happiness nor energy.
- 3 Keep your true image in the first two years of marriage.** Learn to say "no" with confidence — but in a good voice.
- 4 Fulfil both duty and passion.** Living by killing her own wishes is not a woman's dharma; an unfinished duty causes rebirth, and so does a suppressed passion.

- 5 **If needed, raise the idea of living apart for a while with your husband** — without breaking the relationship, and not the "I'll go to my mother's house" kind.
- 6 **Never tolerate atrocities.** If it is within limits, answer yourself; if not, call your parents and take strict action.
- 7 **Liberation is the final aim; the husband is not the final aim.** Regard an obstacle on the path of liberation as equal to a crore of enemies — but leaving the marriage is the last option, not the first.
- 8 **Don't tell your mother everything.** Through the invisible cord between mother and child, a mother's worry has an immediate effect; hearing half the story, out of moha she can damage the whole relationship.
- 9 **Keep contact with your parents' home limited and meaningful** — a real problem, a family occasion, good news. Phoning three times a day is not the mark of a pativrata.
- 10 **The same applies to the mothers of sons** — let your children live independently.